ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

Peer Pressure and Social Life: Keep Your Friends, Keep Your Standards

Make your own decisions about money, alcohol, relationships and belonging

CAMPUS LIFE

Campus Life

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Study smarter. Ask better questions. Pass with understanding.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Freshers face new freedoms and new pressure at the same time. This pack explains how group influence works, gives scripts for refusing without drama, and helps you build friendships that support rather than undermine your goals.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Explain how conformity and social influence affect decisions.
- Recognise pressure around money, alcohol, cultism and relationships.
- Use clear, low-conflict refusal scripts.
- Build a social circle that supports your academic and personal goals.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Why pressure works

Humans are wired to avoid exclusion, and that wiring can override judgement.

- We look to others when unsure, especially in a new environment.
- We conform to avoid standing out or being rejected.
- Small requests escalate; agreeing once makes agreeing again easier.
- Groups create shared stories about what is normal.
- Being tired, lonely or financially stretched increases susceptibility.
- Naming the pressure reduces its power.

Know your lines

Decide your standards before the moment and rehearse simple refusals.

- Direct: 'No, I am not doing that.'
- Redirect: 'I am not drinking, but I will still come for the music.'
- Delay: 'I need to think about it; I will get back to you.'
- Exit: 'I have to go now.'
- Broken record: repeat the same short answer without justifying.
- Refuse cultism and criminal groups absolutely; there is no safe level of involvement.

> **Say no to money pressure**
> Never borrow to match someone else's spending. A friend who mocks your budget is describing their values, not your worth.

Build good friendships

The strongest protection against bad influence is a small group with shared standards.

- Choose friends you would be comfortable introducing to your parents.
- Look for consistency between what people say and do.
- Keep at least one friend who will tell you the truth.
- Invest in people who celebrate your progress rather than compete with it.
- Keep contact with family or a mentor outside campus.
- Ask for help early if you feel trapped or threatened.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Why does conformity increase in new environments?

Answer: Uncertainty makes people rely on others for cues about acceptable behaviour, and the need to belong is strong.

2. Give two refusal scripts.

Answer: 'No, I am not doing that' and 'I need to think about it; I will get back to you.'

3. Why is a broken-record refusal effective?

Answer: It gives no new argument to negotiate against and signals a settled decision.

4. What should you do if a friend is pressuring you financially?

Answer: State your limit clearly, decline, and reconsider how much time you spend with someone who disregards it.

5. Why is cultism a hard no rather than a risk to manage?

Answer: Involvement is criminal, violent and difficult to exit; there is no safe level of participation.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write your personal non-negotiables in three lines.
- [ ] Rehearse two refusal lines aloud.
- [ ] Identify one friend who supports your goals.
- [ ] Set a weekly social budget and stick to it.
- [ ] Know the support contacts for counselling or security.
- [ ] Leave any group that repeatedly ignores your boundaries.
- [ ] Check in on a coursemate who seems isolated.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

> **More from the ZikShare Academic Vault**
> Find faculty primers, study-skills guides, money and career packs, and digital-skills workbooks in the ZikShare Library. New packs are added every semester.

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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